

FOUNDATIONS OF PHILIPPINE POPULAR CULTURE

Culture is the way you see the world, think, and express yourself in daily life. This module explores different types of culture to help you understand how culture shapes your everyday experiences.

Popular Culture

Popular culture (or “pop culture”) refers to the **everyday ideas, practices, and products** embraced by the **public**. It reflects **current trends** and **social values**, evolving with the **interests** and **experiences** of ordinary people **across different communities**.

Characteristics of Popular Culture

Popular Culture can be analyzed through the following key features:

1. **Accessibility** – Pop culture is **easy to understand** and **available to people across ages** and **social classes**.

Local Example: **Barangay fiestas** in both urban and rural areas feature games, food, and contests that welcome people of all ages and backgrounds, which makes pop culture a shared experience.

Global Example: **Outdoor movie nights**, also known as **open-air cinemas** or **drive-in theaters**, are held worldwide and feature popular films for free or at low cost, which makes pop culture more accessible, inclusive, and enjoyable for people from all social classes.

2. **Popularity** – Pop culture becomes **mainstream** because **many people relate** to or **participate** in it.

Local Example: **Jeepney culture** became part of Filipino pop culture not just as a mode of transport, but as a symbol of everyday life, shown through its colorful designs, local artwork, music, and presence in media. It is widely recognized and relatable across generations.

Global Example: **Street basketball** has become popular worldwide through movies, music videos, and urban fashion. Its easy access and power to unite people have turned it into a cultural movement, not just a sport.

3. **Commercialism** – Many elements of pop culture are **created** and **marketed for profit**, such as **fan merchandise, events, and digital content**.

Local Example: **TOYCON PH**, the Philippines’ largest and longest-running convention for toys, hobbies, and collectibles, generates income through the sale of action figures, fan-made art, and other pop culture merchandise. It draws around 50,000 visitors each year from across the country and nearby Asian nations. TOYCON PH is considered the leading pop culture event in the Philippines.

Global Example: Products like **Funko Pop!** figures and **LEGO sets** feature famous movies and TV characters that are widely bought, collected, and traded. This commercialization helps spread pop culture but also raises questions about authenticity and consumerism.

In essence, **accessibility** focuses on how easily **people from all backgrounds** can experience pop culture, while **popularity** centers on the **widespread appeal** and **shared participation**. At the same time, **commercialism** highlights how pop culture is often **driven by profit** through **marketing** and **consumer products**.

High Culture

High culture refers to **artistic and intellectual expressions** associated with **educated and elite sectors of society**. It includes forms valued for their **historical, aesthetic, and intellectual depth**.

Characteristics of High Culture

High Culture is marked by several essential features, such as:

1. **Validation** – High culture is often **supported** and **legitimized** by **formal institutions** such as **museums, orchestras, universities, and cultural centers**, which **preserve, fund, and promote** art forms.

Local Example: The **National Museum of the Philippines** preserves and displays cultural heritage through its nationwide network of museums.

Global Example: The **Metropolitan Museum of Art** in **New York** promotes high culture through its renowned collection and educational programs.

2. **Sophistication** – High culture emphasizes **creativity, intellectual depth**. And **refined techniques**. These works are often studied in **academic settings** and **praised by critics**.

Local Example: The **Philippine Philharmonic Orchestra** is acclaimed for its skilled performances and is frequently featured in cultural and academic events.

Global Example: The compositions of **Johann Sebastian Bach** are studied in music conservatories and performed by symphony orchestras worldwide, admired for their complexity and artistic value.

3. **Exclusivity** – Access to high culture can be **limited by cost, location, or social perception**, often making it **more accessible to privileged groups**.

Local Example: Performances at the **Cultural Center of the Philippines**, such as operas or symphonies, can be expensive and primarily attract audiences from more affluent sectors.

Global Example: Attending performances at **prestigious venues** such as the **Vienna State Opera** is often costly and requires familiarity with classical music.

In essence, **validation** focuses on the **support** from **respected institutions**, **sophistication** highlights the **quality** and **depth** of the work itself, and **exclusivity** points to **limited access** often reserved for the **privileged**.

Folk Culture

Folk culture includes the **customs** and **practices** that **grow within communities** and are shared through **daily interaction** and **participation**. It is not made for profit or mass appeal but **takes everyday forms** like **songs, dances, crafts, and stories**, passed on through **personal** and **communal experience**.

Characteristics of Folk Culture

Folk culture is marked by key features, such as:

1. **Tradition** – Folk culture is rooted in **tradition**, with customs and knowledge **passed down** through generations by word of mouth or daily practice. These practices **maintain cultural continuity** over time.

Local Example: The **Hudhud chants** of the **Ifugao** are an oral tradition performed during agricultural and communal rituals, which preserves ancestral knowledge, values, and history across generations.

Global Example: European folk tales, such as **Little Red Riding Hood** or **Jack and the Beanstalk**, originated in oral storytelling traditions. These stories have been passed down through generations to entertain, impart lessons, and strengthen cultural identity.

2. **Locality** – Folk culture is shaped by locality, which reflects the **distinct practices, materials, and ways** of life tied to a **specific region, environment, or community**.

Local Example: In the **Cordillera Administrative Region**, the traditional **Kalinga tattooing** practice known as **Batok** reflects tribal identity, records personal and social milestones, and represents one's status in the community.

Global Example: In **New Zealand**, the **Māori** practice of **tā moko** is a traditional form of tattooing art that varies by tribe and region and symbolizes identity, ancestry, and cultural belonging.

3. **Symbolism** – Folk culture is rich in **symbolism**, in which **everyday rituals and objects** express **deeper beliefs, spiritual values, or social meanings** central to the community.

Local Example: In **Sagada**, the tradition of **Panag-apoy** involves families lighting bonfires in cemeteries on All Saints' Day to honor and connect with their ancestors. This ritual symbolizes a deep spiritual bond with the past and reinforces communal remembrance.

Global Example: In **Japan**, **Obon** is an annual Buddhist tradition that honors the spirits of ancestors, who are believed to return temporarily to visit their families. Rituals such as lantern lighting and ancestral offerings symbolize reverence for the dead and reinforce spiritual and communal bonds.

In essence, **tradition** focuses on **time and continuity**, **locality** emphasizes **place and setting**, and **symbolism** highlights **meaning and purpose**.

The Role of Cultural Institutions

In the Philippines, key institutions like the **National Commission for Culture and the Arts (NCCA)** and the **Cultural Center of the Philippines (CCP)** play a crucial role in **promoting both high culture and folk culture**.

NCCA (National Commission for Culture and the Arts)

- The **NCCA** was enacted through **Republic Act No. 7356**, which was signed into law on **April 3, 1992**, officially designating it as the **national government agency for culture and the arts in the Philippines**.
- It serves as the country's **overall policymaking, coordinating, and grants-giving body** for the **development and promotion of culture and the arts**.
- The NCCA supports a wide range of cultural expressions, including **indigenous traditions, folk practices, contemporary works, and high art**.
- It **administers national awards** such as the **Gawad sa Manlilikha ng Bayan (GAMABA)** for **National Living Treasures** and **co-administers the Order of National Artists (Orden ng mga Pambansang Alagad ng Sining)** in partnership with the **Cultural Center of the Philippines (CCP)**.

CCP (Cultural Center of the Philippines)

- The **Cultural Center of the Philippines (CCP)** was established in **1966** to **promote and present the performing and visual arts** in the country.
- It primarily focuses on **high culture**, including **classical music, ballet, theater, and visual arts**, but it also features **folk and contemporary works** through **festivals and outreach programs**.
- The CCP regularly **hosts major cultural events and educational initiatives** that span various artistic disciplines.

Example: The **Philippine Pavilion at Expo 2025 Osaka**, opened on **April 13, 2025**, under the theme **"Nature, Culture, and Community: Woven Together for a Better Future,"** highlights the country's rich **cultural heritage** through the largest collaboration of **Filipino weavers**.

The pavilion, supported by the **National Commission for Culture and the Arts (NCCA)** and coordinated by the **Department of Tourism (DOT)** and the **Tourism Promotions Board (TPB)**, features a **woven-inspired design** by **Carlo Calma Consultancy Inc.**, with creative production by **Chochay Garcia**, architect **Yuki Kanou**, **Tellart**, and **Ballet Philippines**. It blends **traditional craftsmanship** with **immersive technology**, displaying how **cultural institutions and government agencies** collaborate to **promote culture, diplomacy, and sustainable development** worldwide.

Indigenous Peoples in the Philippines

Indigenous Peoples have **historical ties** to **pre-colonial societies** and continue to **practice traditional beliefs, oral storytelling, farming, and self-governance**.

Indigenous Peoples (IPs) is a **broad legal term** recognizing the **collective rights of native ethnic groups**, while **Indigenous Cultural Communities (ICCs)** refers to **specific local communities that share common cultural practices and traditions**.

Indigenous Cultural Communities (ICCs) in the Philippines

The Philippines is home to a rich diversity of Indigenous Cultural Communities (ICCs), each with its **distinct languages, traditions, and ways of life**. These communities are spread across the country's three major island regions:

- **Luzon** is home to the **Igorot** of the **Cordilleras**, as well as the **Aeta, Mangyan, and Palawan** peoples. These groups are known for their **deep ties to ancestral land** and their **preservation of traditional practices**.
- **Visayas** is represented by groups such as the **Ati of Panay Island**, who **maintain unique identities despite smaller populations**.
- **Mindanao** is home to the **Lumad**, a **collective term for non-Muslim Indigenous groups**, and the **Moro, Indigenous Muslim communities with rich cultural and historical traditions**.

Despite their contributions to Philippine heritage, Indigenous Cultural Communities **face marginalization, displacement, and discrimination**. The **Indigenous Peoples' Rights Act of 1997 (Republic Act No. 8371 or IPRA)** upholds the **rights of Indigenous communities to ancestral land, self-governance, and cultural integrity**.

The **National Commission on Indigenous Peoples (NCIP)** implements this law, while programs like the **DepEd Indigenous Peoples Education Program (IPED)** promote culture-based learning. The **Indigenous Peoples Mandatory Representative (IPMR)** ensures Indigenous voices are included in local governance.

Indigenous Influence on Folk Culture

Indigenous Cultural Communities are central to the roots of folk culture in the Philippines. Through **oral traditions, rituals, weaving, music, and nature-based practices**, they **preserve cultural heritage and express identity**. Their **close relationship with the land shapes localized and sustainable ways of life**. These traditions continue to **influence and define the character of folk culture today**.

How to Practice Cultural Sensitivity

Cultural sensitivity means **engaging with Indigenous cultures respectfully and responsibly**. It helps **prevent harmful stereotypes** and the **misuse of traditions**, such as **using sacred attire for fashion** or **presenting Indigenous Peoples as one-dimensional**. Respect supports **cultural dignity** and **promotes understanding**.

1. **Engage** – Build knowledge from **reliable sources** and **listen to Indigenous voices** through **books, talks, and direct community engagement**.

Example: Attend a community event or read about Lumad traditions from recognized Indigenous authors or scholars.

2. **Consult** – Always **ask permission** before using **Indigenous designs, symbols, or stories**, especially in **art, media, or products**.

Example: Before using T'boli patterns, consult with T'boli artisans or cultural representatives.

3. **Support** – Give **proper credit** to **Indigenous creators** and **promote their work** fairly.

Example: When sharing a craft made by an Aeta artisan, name the creator and promote ethical ways to support their community.

Cultural Studies Theory

Cultural Studies Theory is an **interdisciplinary field** that explores how culture **connects with power, identity, and society**. It looks at **everyday things** like **media, language, and beliefs** to understand how they shape **how we live and think**. It **uses ideas** from **sociology, literature, and critical theories** like **Marxism and feminism**.

Core Principles of Cultural Studies Theory

Cultural Studies Theory is based on key concepts such as:

1. **Power** – Culture is a space where power is **expressed, challenged, and negotiated**. It is **not neutral**; it reflects who **holds influence** in society. People use culture to **maintain authority** or to **resist dominant norms**.

In short, **culture** can either **uphold existing systems of control** or become a **tool for resistance and change**.

Example: When young people create street art that criticizes the government, they are using culture to push back against political power.

2. **Representation** – The way **people, groups, and issues** are **portrayed in media** and **culture shapes how society understands them**. These representations influence **public opinion** and can **reinforce harmful stereotypes**.

Simply put, **media** can **shape how we view others** and **sometimes** do so in **biased or unfair ways**.

Example: When news outlets focus only on negative stories about a region or culture, it can foster fear and misunderstanding among the broader public.

3. **Interpretation** – Cultural messages are **not interpreted the same way** by everyone. People **understand and react to messages** based on their **personal experiences, beliefs, and social backgrounds**. Audiences play an **active role in making meaning**.

Put simply, people **do not just absorb what culture tells them**. They **create their meaning** based on **who they are**.

Example: The *pagmamano* tradition may be seen as respectful by older generations, while some younger Filipinos might see it as outdated.

Key Theorists and Cultural Contributions

The following thinkers have significantly shaped the way we understand culture, identity, and power through their groundbreaking theories and insights.

- **Stuart Hall (1932-2014)** was a **central figure in Cultural Studies**, best known for developing the **encoding/decoding model**, which **challenged traditional communication theories** by showing how **media audiences actively interpret messages** based on their **social contexts**. His work foregrounded the role of **hegemony, race, and identity**, positioning **culture as a dynamic arena** where **meaning is constantly negotiated and contested**.
- **Raymond Williams (1921-1988)** expanded the scope of cultural analysis by asserting that "**culture is ordinary**," emphasizing **everyday life** and **popular practices** as valid subjects of study. He introduced the idea of "**structures of feeling**" to capture the often **unspoken emotional and cultural experiences** shaped by **historical conditions**. Williams also advanced a **materialist approach**, linking **cultural forms** to their **social and economic foundations**.
- **Antonio Gramsci (1891-1937)**, though **not a Cultural Studies scholar**, deeply influenced the field with his **theory of cultural hegemony**. He argued that **dominant groups maintain power** not only through coercion but by **shaping cultural norms to reflect their interests**. His concept of **organic intellectual** figures emerging from within **marginalized communities** who **challenge dominant ideologies** remains vital to **understanding resistance and agency within culture**.

Applications of Cultural Studies Theory

Cultural Studies is applied in diverse contexts to analyze how culture operates within power structures. Its applications include:

- **Media and Communication** – Cultural Studies examines how **communication practices** and **media use** influence **everyday meaning-making**. It provides a basis for **understanding cultural power and representation**.

Example: Some beauty commercials show fair skin as important for beauty and success.

- **Subcultures and Youth Culture** – Subcultures like **punk, hip-hop, or skateboarding** show how **marginalized groups** create **identities and values** that resist **mainstream norms**. These cultures often reflect issues of **class, race, and generational conflict**.

Example: Some Filipino teens use rap music to talk about problems in society.

- **Postcolonial Studies** – Cultural Studies explores how **colonialism continues to shape identity, language, and representation** in **formerly colonized societies**. It focuses on **cultural hybridity, resistance, and the enduring effects of imperialism on global power and culture**.

Example: Some Filipinos use English more than their native language in school or formal settings.

- **Gender and Queer Studies** – Cultural Studies uses insights from **feminism and queer theory** to examine how **gender roles and gender identities** are **represented and understood in society**. It explores how **media, language, and institutions** influence **perceptions and experiences** related to **gender and sexuality**.

Example: Some teleseryes show women as housewives, not often as leaders.

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